

THE SERMON OF THE SALT-BLIND LEVIATHAN

SPOKEN BENEATH THE ASHEN BELL

Attend, ash-breathed faithful, and lower your faces from the wind.

There is a creature beneath the world's white scars whose coming is not heralded by trumpet, nor by banner, nor by the shining of watchfires. It is called the Salt-Blind Leviathan. Remember the name, not because names grant safety, but because a named terror may be faced without pretending it is merely weather.

The Salt-Blind Leviathan is a siege-breaker of moderate threat. Let no fool mock the word moderate. A measured blade may still open the throat. A contained fire may still consume the storehouse. "Moderate" does not mean harmless. It means only that the terror has been weighed by minds that survived the weighing.

Look upon its likeness in the salt-marked stones: a vast leviathan, its features pale and crusted with salt, its eyes sightless. It cannot trust the road by seeing it. It cannot judge the wall by the glint upon its stones. It cannot follow a torch, nor be turned aside by a painted decoy. The Salt-Blind Leviathan is defined by an inability to rely on sight.

And yet it advances.

This is the lesson the proud refuse. We praise the eye because the eye flatters us. We believe what we see, and we mistake what we see for all that is true. But the Salt-Blind Leviathan does not need the face of the fortress. It knows the fortress through pressure. It finds the gate by resistance. It learns the wall by the sound of its breaking.

Its force is immense destructive force. Its burden is not a sudden rage, but a weight that does not cease. Its demeanor conveys ponderous, relentless pressure. Mark those words upon your hearts: ponderous, relentless pressure. Not haste. Not frenzy. The mountain does not hurry when it crushes the buried house.

Therefore, when the Salt-Blind Leviathan comes, do not waste your strength crying that it cannot see you. It does not need to see you. Do not boast that your walls are tall. Height is only another measure of falling stone. Do not beg the darkness to hide you.

Darkness is no blindness to the thing that was born without sight.

Stand soberly. Brace what may be braced. Carry away what may be carried. *Let the proud hear the grinding beneath the earth and understand: not every warning arrives as a voice.*

The Salt-Blind Leviathan is no demon to be flattered, no beast to be shamed, no storm to be cursed into silence. It is the pressure that comes, and comes, and comes.

Pray, then—not for its eyes to open.

Pray for your hearts not to close.